North India Winter Trip: Overview

5 plans compared · Hyderabad ⇄ Delhi trains (early morning + every-halt method) · flights · winter gear buy vs rent · booking deadlines. Leave 24 Dec 2026, home by 3 Jan 2027 · Budget ₹25–30k per person

The 5 plans side by side

Plan	Where	Snow for these dates	Offbeat level	Crowds	Main transport	Per person (4 ppl): shoestring / recommended
1 · Standard	Shimla, Kufri, Narkanda–Hatu, Manali, Solang, Atal Tunnel–Sissu, Naggar, Sethan, Kasol	Good (Solang /Sissu/Hatu)	★★☆☆☆	High	Train + HRTC Volvo	₹24.6k / ₹30.8k
2 · Offbeat Himachal	Mashobra, Shali Tibba, Narkanda, Thanedar, Jalori, Jibhi, Tirthan, Naggar, Sethan	Good (Hatu/Jalori/Sethan)	★★★★★	Low	Train + Volvo + taxis	₹25.4k / ₹31.2k
3 · Kashmir (my pick)	Srinagar, Gulmarg, Drung, Doodhpathri, Sonamarg, Pahalgam–Aru, Martand	**Best** (Chillai Kalan)	★★★☆☆	Medium	Train + Vande Bharat to Srinagar	₹22.7k / ₹30.4k
4 · Sikkim	Gangtok, Tsomgo–Nathula, Silk Route (Zuluk, Nathang), Aritar, Ravangla, Pelling, Rinchenpong, Darjeeling	At passes/lakes only	★★★★☆	Low–medium	Flights to Bagdogra	₹35.6k / ₹47.3k (lean ≈ ₹31k)
5 · Uttarakhand	Rishikesh, Devprayag, Sari–Deoria Tal, Chopta–Tungnath–Chandrashila, Auli–Gorson, Haridwar	Good on the trek / Auli	★★★☆☆	Low–medium	Train + bus + cab	₹20.1k / ₹30.3k

Recommendation

Want guaranteed snow on budget → Plan 3 (Kashmir). The new Jammu–Srinagar Vande Bharat makes it a train trip, and Gulmarg/Sonamarg/Aru are snow-white by late December.

Want quiet villages and no NYE crowd → Plan 2. Want a proper trek → Plan 5 (cheapest too). **First trip to the hills, want the classics → Plan 1. Plan 4 is the most beautiful for mountain views but only fits ₹30k in its lean form** because of flights.

Budgets assume 4 travellers sharing rooms (2 per room) and cabs, 3A sleeper for 'recommended', SL + dorms/homestays for 'shoestring'. Personal shopping and the one-time winter clothing purchase (≈ ₹4–6.5k if you own nothing) are not included.

Calendar & booking deadlines

Date	Day	What it means
24 Dec 2026	Thursday	Start day. 12285 Duronto (Sun/Thu) runs today. 12437 Rajdhani does not (Wed only).
25 Dec	Friday	Christmas. Hill stations fill up. Most HYD trains reach Delhi this morning.
31 Dec	Thursday	New Year's Eve. Peak hotel rates, long jams near Manali/Solang/Atal Tunnel.
1 Jan 2027	Friday	12286 Duronto NZM→SC runs today (Mon/Fri). Heavy traffic coming down from the hills.
2 Jan	Saturday	Best day to leave Delhi: 12724 Telangana Exp 16:00 or 22692 Rajdhani reaches Hyderabad 3 Jan.
3 Jan	Sunday	Must be home. Keep this day as a buffer only.

Journey date	General booking opened (60-day rule)	Tatkal opens (day before)
24 Dec 2026 (onward)	25 Oct 2026 (already open)	23 Dec: 10:00 AM (AC) / 11:00 AM (SL)
1 Jan 2027 (return)	2 Nov 2026 (already open)	31 Dec: 10:00 / 11:00 AM
2 Jan 2027 (return)	3 Nov 2026 (opened yesterday, book today)	1 Jan: 10:00 / 11:00 AM

Do these 3 things today (4 Nov)

1. Book the **return** train (2 Jan): its 60-day window opened yesterday and Telangana Exp / Rajdhani 3A fill within days in the New Year week.
2. Check the **onward** train (24 Dec) on all the options below using the every-halt method. If everything is WL beyond ~WL 20 (3A), book the flight instead today, because flight fares only go up from here.
3. Book NYE-night stays (31 Dec) with free cancellation. They are the first to sell out in every plan.

Hyderabad → Delhi trains (all options, early morning first)

Train	Boards in Hyderabad	Reaches	Runs	Classes · approx fare / person	Use on 24 Dec?
12723 Telangana SF Exp	Hyderabad Deccan (Nampally) **06:00** · Secunderabad 06:20/06:25	New Delhi ~07:40–08:00 next day (~25.5 h)	Daily	SL ≈ ₹800 · 3A ≈ ₹2,100 · 2A ≈ ₹3,000	**Yes, best early-morning train**
22691 Bengaluru–Nizamuddin Rajdhani	Secunderabad **07:00 arr / 07:10 dep** (10-min halt)	H. Nizamuddin ~05:30 next day (~22 h)	Daily	3A ≈ ₹3,300–4,100 · 2A ≈ ₹4,500–5,500 (flexi fare, meals incl.)	Yes. Fastest morning option
22705 Tirupati–Jammu Tawi Humsafar	Secunderabad ~08:40	Delhi Safdarjung, then Jammu Tawi	Weekly (sources say Tue from Tirupati, so Wed at SC)	3A ≈ ₹3,300–3,900 (to Jammu)	Probably 23 Dec, not 24th. Verify. Useful for Plan 3
12285 Secunderabad–Nizamuddin Duronto	Secunderabad **12:50**	H. Nizamuddin ~10:40 next day (~22 h)	**Sun & Thu**	AC only · 3A ≈ ₹3,000–3,700 (meals incl.)	**Yes, 24 Dec is a Thursday**
12437 Secunderabad–Nizamuddin Rajdhani	Secunderabad 12:50	H. Nizamuddin 10:30 next day	Wed only	3A ≈ ₹3,300–4,000	No (23 Dec only)
12707 AP Sampark Kranti	Kacheguda ~16:30	H. Nizamuddin next day	Mon/Wed/Fri (verify)	SL / 3A / 2A	No (not Thursday)
12721 Dakshin SF Exp	Hyderabad Deccan 23:00	H. Nizamuddin ~03:45 on day 3 (~29 h)	Daily	SL ≈ ₹780 · 3A ≈ ₹2,100	Only as a 23-Dec-night fallback (slow)
Weekly via Kacheguda: 12647 Kongu, 12649 / 12629 Karnataka Sampark Kranti, 12781 Swarna Jayanti	Kacheguda (times vary)	H. Nizamuddin	1–2× a week	SL / 3A / 2A	Check if any runs on 24 Dec

12723 major halts, in order (check availability to each): Hyderabad Deccan → Secunderabad → Kazipet → Ramagundam → Mancherial → Sirpur Kagaznagar → Balharshah → Chandrapur → Sevagram → Nagpur → Itarsi → Bhopal → Jhansi → Gwalior → Agra Cantt → New Delhi (about 18 halts in total, ~1,680 km). Confirmed times: HYB 06:00, SC 06:20/06:25, Kazipet 08:03/08:05, Ramagundam 09:28/09:30. Read the other times off NTES or IRCTC on the day.

If Hyderabad stations are full: board further up the line

Fallback station	Distance from Hyderabad	Daily Delhi trains you can board there (check availability from here too)
Kazipet Jn / Warangal	~140 km · 2–2.5 h by road, or ride 12723 itself	12625 Kerala Exp, 12621 Tamil Nadu Exp, 12615 GT Exp, 20805 AP Exp, 12723 Telangana Exp (Kazipet 08:03)
Ramagundam	~210 km	12723 (09:28), 12625, 12621 and others on the Grand Trunk route
Nagpur	Flight HYD–NAG ~1 h, or bus overnight	30+ Delhi-bound trains a day. Last resort if everything from Telangana is full

How to check every halt and actually get a seat

- **Step 1. Direct pairs.** On IRCTC (or ConfirmTkt / ixigo, same data), search 24 Dec for HYB→NDLS, SC→NDLS, SC→NZM, HYB→NZM in 3A and SL. Note the status for each train: AVAILABLE / RAC / WL number.
- **Step 2. Every halt (as you asked).** If HYB/SC→Delhi shows WL, search the same train from **HYB** to each later halt: Agra Cantt, Gwalior, Jhansi, Bhopal, Itarsi, Nagpur. Seats are split into quotas by distance, so a shorter ticket (e.g. HYB→Agra) can be AVAILABLE while HYB→Delhi is WL. If Agra/Gwalior is available, book it, ride to Agra (about 4 h before Delhi), then take any Agra→Delhi train, Gatimaan/Vande Bharat or bus (2–3.5 h, ₹300–800).
- **Step 3. Book from the train's origin.** For trains that start outside Hyderabad (22691 Rajdhani from Bengaluru, 22705 Humsafar from Tirupati), search **origin→Delhi** (SBC→NZM, TPTY→NZM/Jammu) and set **Boarding Point = Secunderabad**. You pay the full-route fare, but the origin's general quota is often open when the Secunderabad quota is full.
- **Step 4. Board further up the line.** Check the same trains from Kazipet / Ramagundam (table above). You can book HYB→Delhi and board at SC, but you cannot board before the boarding station on your ticket.
- **Step 5. Split journey.** HYB→Nagpur (many trains, short) + Nagpur→Delhi (30+ trains, incl. Rajdhanis from the south). Leave at least 2–3 h for the change.
- **Step 6. Tatkal on 23 Dec.** AC Tatkal opens 10:00 AM, sleeper 11:00 AM. You need an Aadhaar-authenticated IRCTC account (OTP). Log in at 9:55 with saved passenger lists and UPI ready. Premium Tatkal costs more but is easier to get.
- **Step 7. Tick 'Vikalp' and 'auto-upgradation'** when booking a WL ticket. Book WL only if the WL number is low (roughly under WL 20 in 3A, 40 in SL, 50 days out). Otherwise fall back to flights (next table).

Why I can't give you live 'available / WL' numbers here

IRCTC and the seat-availability pages need a login and captcha, and the availability sites were not reachable from this environment. Everything above (train numbers, days, timings, fares) is researched; the availability check takes 10 minutes with the steps above. Do it in the ConfirmTkt or ixigo Trains app, which also show WL-confirmation chances and alternate-station suggestions.

Delhi → Hyderabad (home by 3 Jan)

Train	Leaves	Reaches Hyderabad	Runs	Approx fare (3A)	Fits 'home by 3 Jan'?
12724 Telangana SF Exp	New Delhi **16:00**	Hyderabad Deccan ~17:10 next day	Daily	≈ ₹2,100 (SL ≈ ₹800)	**Leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan evening**
22692 Nizamuddin–Bengaluru Rajdhani	H. Nizamuddin late evening (≈20:30–21:00, verify)	Secunderabad 17:10 arr / 17:25 dep next day	Daily	≈ ₹3,300–4,100	**Leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan 17:10**
12286 Nizamuddin–Secunderabad Duronto	H. Nizamuddin 15:55	Secunderabad ~14:35 next day	Mon & Fri	≈ ₹3,000–3,700	Leave 1 Jan (Fri) → home 2 Jan
12722 Dakshin SF Exp	H. Nizamuddin 22:50	Hyderabad Deccan ~03:50 on day 3	Daily	≈ ₹2,100	Leave 1 Jan night → home 3 Jan 04:00
12438 Nizamuddin–Secunderabad Rajdhani	H. Nizamuddin 15:35	Secunderabad 13:40 next day	Sunday only	≈ ₹3,300–4,000	No (3 Jan departure is too late)
22706 Jammu Tawi–Tirupati Humsafar	Jammu Tawi 05:45	Secunderabad ~18:00 next day	Weekly (verify day)	≈ ₹3,300–3,900	Only Plan 3, and only if it runs 1 Jan

Flights from Hyderabad

Route (non-stop)	Airlines	Flight time	Typical Dec–Jan one-way fare*	Useful for
Hyderabad ↔ Delhi	IndiGo, Air India, Akasa, SpiceJet (many daily)	~2 h 10 m	₹6,000–9,000 (24 Dec / 2 Jan can touch ₹10–12k)	Plans 1, 2, 3, 5
Hyderabad → Chandigarh	IndiGo (≈2 daily)	~2 h 30 m	₹7,000–9,500	Plans 1 & 2 (Shimla is 3–4 h from IXC)
Hyderabad ↔ Srinagar	IndiGo, Air India Express	~3 h	₹9,600–11,100 (peak days up to ~₹15,700)	Plan 3
Hyderabad ↔ Bagdogra	IndiGo (+ Air India Express)	~2 h 15 m–2 h 30 m	₹6,500–8,500 (peak ₹9–12k)	Plan 4
Hyderabad ↔ Dehradun	IndiGo (≈10 flights/week, ~10:25 dep on some days)	~2 h 25 m	₹5,000–9,000	Plan 5

*Snapshot ranges from MakeMyTrip, Goibibo, Skyscanner, HappyFares and ixigo pages seen in Nov 2026, not live quotes. IndiGo cabin bag: 7 kg; check-in 15 kg on most fares. Winter jackets count, so wear the heaviest layers on the plane. Book within the next 1–2 weeks: Christmas/New Year fares on these routes usually climb steadily.

Mix that saves time	Extra cost vs all-train	Days gained in the hills
Train out + fly back (Delhi/IXC/SXR/DED → HYD on 2 Jan)	+₹4–8k	+1 (Kashmir: +1.5)
Fly out + train back	+₹4–8k	+1
Fly both ways	+₹10–17k	+2. Over budget for Plans 1, 2, 3 and 5

Winter gear: full list, buy vs rent

Budget for gear: if you own nothing warm, expect ₹4,000–6,500 one-time purchase (thermals, fleece, gloves, cap, socks, sunglasses) + ₹800–1,500 in rentals on the trip (jacket, suit, boots, spikes). The per-plan budgets include only the **rental** part; the purchases you keep are listed separately.

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Thermal inner set (top + bottom) ×2	Must	₹800–1,200 per set (local ₹400–600)	Not rented (hygiene)	Buy. Merino/poly, not cotton
Fleece / sweater (mid layer)	Must	₹600–1,200	—	Buy

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Padded / down jacket (rated −5 to −10 °C)	Must	₹2,500–5,000	Indiahikes rentals ₹55–80/day (ships to you); trek operators ₹100/day; Manali / Gulmarg shops ₹150–300/day	Rent if you'll never use it again. 10 days ≈ ₹600–1,000
One-piece snow suit	At snow points	—	Solang/Palchan, Kufri, Gulmarg, Tsomgo ₹250–500/day (often with gumboots)	Rent on the spot only on snow days
Gumboots / snow boots	At snow points	—	₹100–200/day (Lachung ~₹100; bundled with suit at Solang ₹400–500)	Rent on the spot
Waterproof trekking shoes	Must (Plans 2, 4, 5)	₹2,000–3,500 (Decathlon MH100/MH500)	Trek operators ₹100–150/day	Buy if you'll trek again
Waterproof gloves + woollen inners	Must	₹300–900 + ₹150	—	Buy
Woollen cap / balaclava / neck gaiter	Must	₹200–400 each	—	Buy
Woollen socks (4 pairs)	Must	₹400–600	—	Buy
UV400 sunglasses	Must on snow	₹300–800	—	Snow glare causes snow-blindness
Microspikes + gaiters	Chopta, Hatu, Jalori, Gulmarg walks	₹1,200–1,800	Chopta/Sari/Sankri ₹150–250/day; gaiters ₹100/day	Rent
Trekking pole	Treks	₹400–700	₹50–100/day	Rent
Ski kit (skis, boots, poles)	Optional	—	Gulmarg ≈ ₹700/day + jacket ₹300 + trouser ₹200; Solang ski + instructor ₹1,000–1,500/hr	Optional activity
Cold cream, SPF 50, lip balm, hand-warmers	Must	₹500–700 total	—	Buy

Where to buy before you leave Hyderabad

- **Decathlon** (several stores in Hyderabad, plus online): thermals (Wedze), fleece, Quechua padded jackets, MH100/MH500 shoes, gloves, socks.
- Hyderabad's Koti / Begum Bazaar and Sunday markets: cheaper woollens, caps, socks (₹100–300).
- Delhi: Sarojini Nagar / Janpath / Monastery Market (Majnu ka Tilla) for cheap jackets if you have a few hours on 25 Dec.
- Online rentals that ship to you: Indiahikes rentals (padded jacket rated −10 °C ≈ ₹55–80/day), trek-operator rental shops (₹100/day jackets).

Layering for −10 °C (what to wear on a snow day)

Layer	What	Why
Base	Thermal top + bottom (synthetic/merino)	Keeps sweat off the skin
Mid	Fleece / woollen sweater	Traps heat
Outer	Padded/down jacket + rented snow suit on snow days	Wind and wet protection
Extremities	Woollen cap + balaclava, inner + waterproof gloves, 2 pairs of socks, gumboots/trek shoes, UV sunglasses	Hands, feet, ears and eyes go first

Carry list & safety

Carry list

- Original photo ID (Aadhaar/DL) + 2 photocopies + **4 passport photos** (Sikkim permits, J&K checks).
- Power bank (cold drains batteries 2× faster), offline Google Maps, cash ₹5–8k (ATMs fail in snow areas).
- Basic meds: Diamox (only after a doctor's advice) for Nathula / Chandrashila / Zuluk, paracetamol, ORS, cold & cough tabs, band-aids, Vaseline.
- Small daypack, reusable bottle, thermos (hot water in −5 °C mornings), quick-dry towel, plastic bags for wet gear.
- Prepaid SIMs from outside J&K do not work in Kashmir. Carry at least one **postpaid** connection (Plan 3).

Safety & buffers

- Snow and roads change by the hour. Check HP/J&K/Sikkim/Uttarakhand police traffic updates and ask your homestay every evening. National emergency: **112**. HP disaster helpline: **1077**.
- Do not ride rented two-wheelers on fresh snow or black ice (Solang–Atal Tunnel, Narkanda, Gulmarg road, Chopta). Taxis with snow chains are safer after snowfall.
- Book stays for 24 Dec–1 Jan **in advance** (NYE rates in Manali/Shimla/Gulmarg/Darjeeling go 2–3× normal). Prefer free-cancellation rates.
- Keep 3 Jan as a pure buffer: plan to start the last long leg (hills → Delhi/airport) by 1 Jan, because snow and NYE traffic delay buses 3–8 h.

What's in each PDF

- Overview (this file): comparison, all trains and flights, every-halt method, gear.
- Each plan PDF: how to get there and back for that plan, local transport with prices, a day-by-day itinerary with stay and spend per day, main vs offbeat places, bike/scooty rentals with rates and rules, gear rental points on that route, an itemised budget, what to book now, a Plan B for snow and traffic, and sources.

Sources checked

Reddit could not be searched from this environment (blocked), so traveller reports came from Team-BHP, Tripoto, travel blogs and local news. Live seat availability and live fares could not be fetched (IRCTC needs login and captcha). Use the checklists above to verify.

— IRCTC 60-day ARP (from 1 Nov 2024) & 2026 Aadhaar-verified booking updates: Business Today, India TV, Upstox, Trainman blog, india.com, Patrika, DeshGujarat
— Hyderabad–Delhi train data: Wikipedia (Telangana Exp, Secunderabad Rajdhani, Duronto, Dakshin Exp), ConfirmTkt, totaltraininfo, ixigo, Trainman, RailMitra, gettraininfo, travelkhana, etrain.info, indiantrain.in
— 22691/22692 Bengaluru Rajdhani at Secunderabad: ConfirmTkt, RailMitra, travelkhana
— 22705/22706 Humsafar: ixigo, RailMitra, NativePlanet, Goibibo, Adani One (running days conflict; verify)
— Vande Bharat Sleeper Delhi–Secunderabad: not launched as of Hyderabad Mail (2 Nov 2026); Charlapalli–Nizamuddin specials 07023/07021: indiarailinfo, Curly Tales
— Flights: MakeMyTrip, Goibibo, ixigo, Skyscanner, HappyFares, Air India / Air India Express route pages, IndiGo route pages, flightconnections (Nov 2026)
— Gear rental rates: Indiahikes rentals, Himalayan Hikers, Himalayan Dream Treks, SharePal, travelcoffee.in, cliffhangersindia, Tripoto